



By R. BALKI

"We need stars like him to keep the magic of cinema alive"

People talk about his angry young man persona and his comic flair but it's **a scene in *Dostana*** (right) where he's teasing Zeenat Aman that, for me, is the essence of Amitabh Bachchan—sarcasm delivered with a poker face.

For me, he is more special than the characters he plays. While writing, I preserve the myth of Amitabh Bachchan. How can you bring a lot of Bachchan into the characters? Otherwise, what is the point of having a phenomenon like him and losing him in the character? You have to do justice to him, even if you go overboard sometimes and keep correcting yourself on the way.



We get along because we don't talk much. He is a man of few words, so am I. I don't want to be his friend, I pride myself in being his biggest fan. I like the mystique of Amitabh Bachchan and don't want to crack it. With many actors, once you crack it, you see them as human beings. We need stars like him to keep the magic of cinema alive. I can't find that magic without him. Open your mouth, say the words, without expression but still convey a hundred thousand emotions, that's Bachchan for you. ■

***R. Balki has directed Big B in* Cheeni Kum, Paa, Shamitabh *and penned cameos for* Ki & Ka *and* Chup**

Film studies professor Aysha Iqbal Viswamohan attributes Bachchan's mass appeal in his first wave to his ability to lend authenticity to the working-class hero

already launched his two other books, Ausaja is hopeful his idol will do the honours this time too in December.

MAKING/ PRESERVING HISTORY

As his cult grew, Bachchan became distinctly aware of his own distinct place in Indian cinema. Filmmaker, archivist and restorer Shivendra Singh Dungarpur, who founded the Film Heritage Foundation of which Bachchan is a brand ambassador, notes that the actor preserved 35mm celluloid of his films like *Mili*, *Chupke Chupke*, *Zanjeer* and *Don* in an air-conditioned room at his Juhu house. Audiences in 18 cities can watch 11 of his 1970s and '80s classics from October 8-11 at


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